

ITEM WISE EDITORIAL ... 21st June, 2019



WAR CLOUDS NEAR STRAIT OF HORMUZ



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EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

21st JUNE, 2019

Blast From The Past

US must abandon notions of forced regime change in Iran

Tensions are again on the rise in the Middle East as the US is sending a thousand more troops to the region, in response to Iran's announcement that it would soon breach limits on the amount of enriched uranium it can stockpile under the 2015 nuclear deal. The latter caps Iran's stock of low-enriched uranium at 300 kg. But Iran's Atomic Energy Organisation has said it has quadrupled the rate of enrichment and will breach the stockpile limit soon, unless other parties fulfil their commitments as per the 2015 deal.

The US, which pulled out of the accord last year, is now blaming Iran for nuclear blackmail and insists that the regime in Tehran is out to destabilise the Middle East. But Iran has so far stuck to all the stipulations of the nuclear accord, which even American internal assessment acknowledges. US military intervention at this stage, perhaps driven by the old and discredited neo-conservative agenda of regime change and forcible export of democracy would be disastrous. It would be a replay of the Iraq fiasco which destabilised the global order, gave rise to IS and pushed Russia into adopting an aggressive stance.

In fact, war with Iran will be several times worse than the Iraq military campaign given the Islamic Republic's stature, history and influence in the Middle East. Besides, US President Donald Trump came to power in 2016 on the promise of winding up America's military engagements abroad. America is war weary and a military confrontation with Iran will be unpopular at home and disrupt Trump's own support base. Hence, Trump must resist the neo-conservatives in his administration. Meanwhile, Tehran too should stick to the stipulations of the nuclear deal and not betray the Europeans who have continued to hold the accord together despite the US pullout. Provocations on all sides must be avoided.



EDITORIAL DISCUSSION

Tension in the Persian Gulf

The US and Iran are muddying the waters with accusations and counter-accusations

DEEPA ANAND



The U.S. administration's strategy to counter Iran on the nuclear front is being met with an alleged new strategy that has left the global security community baffled in more ways than one. It is being suggested that shipping vessels be provided naval escorts through the Persian Gulf and the Strait of Hormuz, something reminiscent of World War II when most merchant ships would be provided with naval security. Two oil tankers, one belonging to the Norwegian shipping company Frontline and the other a Japanese vessel, Tokai Maru, were subordinated to the Strait of Hormuz by what the American central command calls 'insider' times, apparently manufactured in Iran. Speculation has been rife over who may have conducted such a sophisticated attack in a sea route through which 60% of the world's traded oil passes. The U.S. blames Iran for the sabotage attacks, even releasing videos and photographs of the incident in an attempt to prove Iranian involvement, something Tehran has vehemently denied.

The situation in the Gulf has been brewing for a few months now and there can be multiple ways to read it. Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe was on a state visit to Tehran, hoping to mediate between the two rivals, when the Japanese tanker was attacked.

To believe either side of the story, without evidence, would be misleading. However, geopolitics in most instances does not come in black or white – rather, it's all grey. The U.S.'s decision to unilaterally pull out of the Iran nuclear deal and impose sanctions on Iran for its nuclear programme has not gone down well with Tehran; the global community too has not appreciated the move. The American side of the story is that Iran is meeting economic and diplomatic manoeuvres with violent attacks by pulling off sophisticated sabotage on the seas. Iranians, on the other hand, proclaim that it is the American intelligence apparatus that is conducting such moves to escalate the situation to the brink of war, thus paving the way for yet another 'promotion of democracy' in West Asia.

Iran has been at the wrong end of American sanctions for decades now, and it has learned to negotiate its way each time with creative new strategies. However, the recent U.S. pressure on countries such as India, Japan and Turkey to reduce their oil imports from Iran to zero has hit Tehran where it hurts most. And this new strategy of sabotaging oil supply routes in the Persian Gulf may be Iran's 'creative' way of dealing with American absolutism. It might well be Iran's way of looking at the adverse situation created by the U.S.: 'If we can't ship oil, might as well let no one else do it too.'

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations

Effect of policies and politics of developed and developing countries on India's interests, Indian diaspora.

DRAFT QUESTION

Regime change with military interventions could not herald democratic governance in various countries. Discuss.



THE TIMES OF INDIA
20th June, 2019



21st June, 2019

28 Blast from the past

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In fact, war with Iran will be several times worse than the Iraq military campaign given the Islamic Republic's stature, history and influence in the Middle East. Besides, US President Donald Trump came to power in 2016 on the promise of winding up America's military engagements abroad. America is war weary, and a military confrontation with Iran will be unpopular at home and disrupt Trump's own support base. Hence, Trump must resist the neo-conservatives in his administration. Meanwhile, Tehran too should stick to the stipulations of the nuclear deal and not betray the Europeans who have continued to hold the accord together despite the US pullout. Provocations on all sides must be avoided.

This piece appeared as an editorial opinion in the print edition of The Times of India.

28 Tension in the Persian Gulf

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The U.S. administration's strategy to counter Iran on the nuclear front is being met with an alleged new strategy that has left the global security community baffled in more ways than one. It is being suggested that shipping vessels be provided naval escorts through the Persian Gulf and the Strait of Hormuz, something reminiscent of World War II when most merchant ships would be provided with naval security.

Two oil tankers, one belonging to the Norwegian shipping company Frontline and the other a Japanese vessel, Kokuka Courageous, were sabotaged in the Strait of Hormuz by what the American central command calls limpet mines, apparently manufactured in Iran. Speculation has been rife over who may have conducted such a sophisticated attack in a sea route through which 40% of the world's traded oil passes. The U.S. blames Iran for the sabotage attacks, even releasing videos and photographs of the incident in an attempt to prove Iranian involvement, something Tehran has vehemently denied.

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GEO-POLITICS

- ◆ It is the study of the influence of such factors as **geography, economics, and demography** on the politics and **especially the foreign policy of a state.**
- ◆ It is the analysis of the geographic influences on power relationships in international relations.
- ◆ In a much broader sense, Geopolitics can be defined as a discipline that studies the relations and interactions between Spaces (Territories), States, Civilizations, Peoples, and Economics.





A BRIEF ON IRAN

- Officially “Islamic Republic of Iran” also known as Persia
- Extends from Caspian Sea to Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman
- One of the world’s largest proven oil reserves and natural gas reserves
- Islamic Republic, with the concept of “Supreme Leader”
- Population ... 8 crores (approx.)
- Capital .. Tehran
- Currency ... Rial
- Known for “Islamic Revolution” of 1979
- Global leader for “Shia Muslim Sect”
- Antagonized USA & West for the past “35 years”
- Sanctions were lifted only in 2015 after the “historic nuclear deal” with world powers E3/EU+3
- Official language ... Persian
- It supports Shia Militias in several countries

WHAT IRAN WAS PERCEIVED AS DOING PRIOR TO 2015?

- Advanced nation's contention is that Iran is building nuclear weapons.
- Hence, international sanctions were imposed since 2006.
- But, Iran is insisting that its nuclear activities are entirely peaceful.
- On and off talks for 12 years, culminated with an agreement in 2015.

WHAT ARE THE SALIENT POINTS OF THE DEAL?

- Iran agreed to get rid of 98% of its stockpile of enriched uranium.
- Centrifuges, which are needed to enrich uranium will be reduced from 19,000 to 6,000.
- Enrichment will be stopped at underground Fordow facility.
- Strict inspection by IAEA.
- UN arms embargo will remain in place for 5 years.
- Embargo on missiles will be there for 8 years.



Donald Trump was not happy with the deal and he came out of it stating that the deal cannot prevent Iran manufacturing Nuclear Weapons. Iran may get space to build Nuclear bomb.

ENRICHED URANIUM

What do you understand?



Natural uranium
>99.2% U-238
0.72% U-235



Low-enriched uranium
(reactor grade)
3-5% U-235



Highly enriched uranium
(weapons grade)
90% U-235

WHY STRAIT OF HORMUZ IS INTO THE NEWS?



USA VERSION

Iran is resorting to economic and diplomatic maneuvers with violent attacks with sabotage on the seas.

IRAN VERSION

American intelligence is conducting such moves to escalate the situation to the brink of war.

- 40% of the World's traded oil passes through this.
- Two oil tankers, belongs to Norway and Japan were sabotaged in the Strait of Hormuz by what USA calls limpet mines, manufactured apparently in Iran.
- A limpet mine is a type of naval mine attached to a target by magnets. They are set off by a time fuse.
- U.S. blames Iran for the sabotage attacks.
- Japanese Prime Minister was on a state visit to Tehran, hoping to mediate between two rivals.

IRAN WILL BREACH THE LIMIT OF ENRICHED URANIUM!

- Iran announced that it would soon breach limits on the amount of enriched uranium it can stockpile under the 2015 Nuclear Deal.
- Iran Nuclear deal caps Iran's stock of low-enriched uranium at 300 kg and it said it will breach the stockpile limit soon unless other parties fulfil their commitments as per the 2015 deal.
- The recent US Pressure on countries such as India, Japan and Turkey to reduce their oil imports from Iran to zero has hit Tehran.

However, USA is now blaming Iran for Nuclear blackmail. It says that the regime in Tehran is out to destabilise the Middle East.



MILITARY INTERVENTION IN IRAN IS NOT GOING TO BE THAT EASY

WHAT HAPPENED IN IRAQ?

- It is pertinent to note, what happened after Iraq was attacked.
- It destabilised the global order.
- It gave rise to Islamic State.
- It pushed Russia into adopting an aggressive stance.

Provocations from all the sides should be avoided.

BE CAUTIOUS ABOUT IRAN!

- US military intervention, driven by the old neo-conservative agenda of the “regime change” and establishment of “democratic government” will not take place.
- War with Iran will be several times worse than the Iraq military campaign.



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